

1943, January 3

The following is a faithful transcription of a carbon copy of the typed original by the Servant of God, Father Solanus Casey, O. F. M. Cap.

Detroit, Michigan
January 3, 1943

Mr. Charles Bracken
Traverse City, Michigan

My dear Mr. Bracken:

God bless you and yours. I hope the outlook for you son is brightening since you wrote me last week. At all events, I hope we can help him. In fact, I think I ought to say, "Thanks be to God, I am confident that we can help him." This especially, if you and Mrs. Bracken and your friends who are interested, will do your part - each in his way. First, I want to tell you that I had an experience of skin-trouble similar to that of which you write your son is having and can sympathize with him even according to the little stanza:

"The mourners tear hath furrowed kindly faces,
And left the light of love abiding there,
Sweet sympathy and tender deeds are traces
Of pain and sorrow soothed in silent prayer."

You tell me that Mrs. Bracken is not Catholic. I hope she as well as yourself - both of you - are earnest about saving your own souls. However, I am convinced more and more every day that such afflictions - in fact, that the trials and crosses of life in general - are sent us or at least permitted, primarily to wake us up and make us do better; in other words, "to switch us into line" in right thinking, and bring to our minds something of the shortness of things earthly - joys and pleasures as well as sorrows and disappointments, etc., and thus incline us to appreciate Eternity and the Eternal. Hence the old saying: "Whom the Lord loveth, He chastiseth."

Now, what can we each of us do to help to induce the Good God to lift this cross from the boy? If you send me his name, I shall inscribe him in our missionary work whereby he will have the benefits of prayers and holy Masses continually and, in a way may become - indirectly a foreign missionary. The inclosed booklet will give you necessary details. Then you can go more frequently to Holy Communion if possible and have the others of the family do the same. This is one thing that I have been advising Catholics to do for years and I assure you, in many cases, with quite astonishing results. Of course, Mrs. Bracken cannot join in this for the present at least. Let her do something in her own honest way; whatever she may deem most pleasing to the dear Lord - only that she be earnest about it and as confident as possible.